"SEPARATE MAINTENANCE"

BY

WINNIFRED REEVE

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SEPARATE MAINTENANCE

A Play in 3 acts and 5 scenes by:

WINNIFRED REEVE

(Onoto Watanna)

Note:

The title is temporary. Other titles possible:

THE MARRIAGE RACKET

ILLEGITIMATE

SENSATION

SO SHALL YE REAPE

LEGAL SEPARation

CO-RESPONDENT.

SEPARATE MAINTENANCE

Act I.

SCENE.

LIVING ROOM OF THE JARROTT RESIDENCE

This is a large, very modern and up to date room. Charming and spacious.

A stairway to one side leads to a gallery above, which opens into bedrooms.

French windows and doors occupy nearly all of the back and open upon a sun porch and solarium.

Slightly under the stairway is an alcove, with a large set in couch, at the end of which is a table, with a telephone on it.

Exits on either side, giving to other rooms, also at back. A reception hall indicated at rear, on which the front door opens.

AT RISE

Young Ray Jarrott cross the room and goes to foot of stairway.

Ray is in evening clothes and is a nice looking youth, of the highly temperamental and sensitive type.

SEPARATE MAINTENANCE

Drama in three acts

by: WINNIFRED REEVE

TIME:----------The Present

Place----------A small American city.

CHARACTERS:

SYLVIA JARROTT
A very beautiful woman

RAY JARROTT
Her son, 21 years old.

ELENA JARROTT
Her daughter, about 17 years old.

SENATOR BRUNDAge

WILLIAM STURTEVANT
President First National Bank.

MRS STURTEVANT
His wife.

MARJORIE STURTEVANT
His daughter

CHESTER WHITEHOUSE (Bunk)

HAL STEWArt
Of the United Press

CAMERAman

JAMES
Butler

MINETTE and Delia
Maids in Jarrott home.

A Process server.

RAY
(Calling)

Oh Mamma! I say--Mamma!

MRS. JARROTT
(Off-stage)

Yes dear.

RAY

Are'nt you ready yet.

MRS. JARROTT

Not quite.

RAY

But its nearly eight.

MRS. JARROTT

I'll be down in a moment.

(Ray is restless. Glances at watch. Picks up a book --puts it down.

Enter from back ELENA. She does not see Ray, but goes to the telephone. She is a pretty, romantic type--thrilly and exclamatory)

ELENA
(At telephone)

'Lo! Can I speak to Bunk?

Oh is that you Bunk?

(At the sound of his sister's voice Ray has moved around to a position where he can watch her. His young brow knits sternly, and it is clear he does not approve of the conversation)

I don't know about tonight, Bunk. If I can slip out I will.

Not so easy as you think. You see the Sturtevant's are coming over.

Yessir, the whole darned family, but perhaps I can slip out and won't be missed. Come on over anyway. Whistle outside the house, and I'll know its you.

RAY
(Sharply)

Elena!

ELENA
(Still at phone)

Whee! There's Ray. Bye, darling!

(Hangs up phone and swaggers out into room, returning her brother's condemning look with pretty defiance)

RAY

Who were you talking to?

ELENA

Bunk, of course.

RAY

And you call that fellow darling.

ELENA

Well why not? I suppose you never call Marjorie Sturtevant darling, eh?

RAY

Thats an entirely different matter. Besides---I'll tell you something Elena. Marjorie and I are engaged!

(Elena stares at him agape with delight and excitement. Then she leaps at him)

ELENA

Why Ray Jarrett! You old walrus you! When are you going to be married? Where'll we have the wedding? Where'll you go on your honeymoon. I'll be the bridesmaid. I'm going right upstairs and tell mamma.

RAY

You'll do nothing of the sort. Which reminds me it must be eight now. Gee whiz!
(Looks at watch)

ELENA

I'm bursting to tell it to everybody. I bet it'll be in the papers tomorrow.
(Giving Ray an ecstatic squeeze)
Won't I have an earful to tell Bunk tonight.

RAY

You can't go out tonight. The Sturtevants are coming.

ELENA

To take our nummer I suppose.
(Laughs)
Feature Mamma and Mrs. Sturtevant together. That gives me a kick.

RAY
(Stiffly)
Whats there funny about that?

ELENA

We-el, the Sturtevants are so good-Goddish.

RAY

They just happen to be a little --er---exclusive and---

ELENA

Thats a lot of Hooey.

RAY

Say, where do you pick up all those cheap slang expressions anyway. I wish you'd cut it out-----before my friends anyway.

ELENA

Meaning the Sturtevants I suppose. Of course, Marjorie never uses such words as hooey, or bugs or bologny or hot diggitty dog or damittohell or---

RAY

No she does'nt! Marjorie's---perfect.

(Elena laughs)

(Mrs. Jarrott enters on the gallery above. She looks down a moment at her children, smiling, and then comes down the stairs. She is very lovely, and very smartly dressed. A quite exquisite person).

MRS. JARROTT

Are you children quarrelling ?

MAMMA

Mamma, guess what? Ray and Marjorie are -----

RAY

Wait a bit. I'll tell mamma myself.

ELENA

OKE. Spill the beans then.

RAY

Mamma, Marjorie and I are engaged.

(Mrs. Jarrott is palpably taken aback, but she smiles brightly)

MRS JARROTT

Why Ray! You're too young to get married, dear. You've oceans of time.

RAY

Well, her people don't think that. Mr. Sturtevant said he believed in early marriages.

(MRS JARROTT)
(Rather faintly; she realizes Ray is serious)

You've already spoken to them?

RAY

Yes, this afternoon. Marjorie thought we ought to.

MRS JARROTT
(Disturbed)

That explains their coming here tonight. They've never called on us before.

RAY

Well, you know how they are mamma---they're considered the most exclusive people in the city.

ELENA

Exclusive my eye!

RAY

You would'nt understand.

MRS JARROTT

Oh you're so young, Ray. I never dreamed of anything like this.

RAY

RAY

I'm not so darned young. You forget I'm twenty one. Every fellow gets married sooner or later.

MRS JARROTT

But you've another year at college.

RAY

I'm going to cut that. Mr. Sturtevant's taking me into the bank with him. I'm going to start from the ground up.

MRS. JARROTT
(More and more upset)

What will your father say?

RAY

I'm not worrying about dad. He's always let us have our way. Dad's swell, and I've only got one thing against him---his darned absence now.

MRS JARROTT

Yes--yes--he's away. He was called out of town on important business.

(Puts hands impulsively on Ray's shoulders)

Look here, darling, lets not take this seriously. Wait 'till we've all talked it over together. What do you say?

RAY

Thats just why they're coming tonight---to talk it over.

MRS JARROTT

I mean--talk it over among ourselves---your father and I. I don't want to see these people Ray. They are perfect strangers to us.

RAY

1~~~

stay here.

MRS. JARROTT

We're planning to go abroad-----

RAY

I don't want to go abroad . Lets stay home for a change. I tell you mamma, I'm going to stay right here.
(Mrs. Jarrott sighs)
Now let me look you over.
(He holds her off at arms length and critically examines her)
I want you to look your best tonight.
(Takes out handkerchief and wipes some rouge from her cheek)

MRS JARROTT

What are you doing Ray.

RAY

Taking some of that makeup off. I don't think mothers ought to make up anyway.

MRS JARROTT

Why Ray--how absurd you are.

RAy

Well it makes you look too young and --er--- and
(Wiping her lips)

MRS JARROTT
(Half amused half hurt)

I'm sorry you don't like my looks Ray.

RAY

Well, I do, but I don't like the makeup. Mrs. Sturtevant does'nt use a thing on her face.

ELENA

Thats why she looks like a dill pickle.

RAY

She does not. Mrs. Sturtevant looks like a ---a --- lady.

ELENA

Is that so? And I'd like to know what you think mamma looks like. You have your nerve to criticise her.

RAY

I'm not criticising her. I only wanted to help her. You don't mind, mamma, do you?

MRS. JARROTT

Oh no, I don't mind. Anything else about me thats not right.

(She turns around like a mannequin for her son's inspection. Ray takes it all dead seriously as he examines her)

RAY

Where did you get that dress?

MRS JARROTT

Its a French Import.

RAY

Kind of flashy, is'nt it?

MRS JARROTT

(Provoked, but humoring him)

Maybe for Edmonton, Ray.

RAY

What do you mean---Edmonton. Is that a slam at this town.

ELENA

Whee! What civic pride. We are noble patriots of Edmonton!

(Strikes attitude. Ray is furious)

RAY

Keep quiet, will you.

ELENA

Well not while your picking on mamma. She's just right--lovely.

RAY

Who said she was'nt?

ELENA

You did, and anyway ever since you've been going around with those God Almighty Sturtevants you've been getting more and more snobby and ritzy. Snap out of it, idiot!

RAY

Sshi I think I hear them coming.

(Sound of motor outside, and shortly the front door bell)

(In the interval, before the entrance of the Sturtevants, Ray hardly knows what he is doing. He leads his mother to a seat, and arranges her dress even, as one of her shapely legs shows through a slash on skirt).

I told James to show them in here. Its more intimate--more as if they were in the family--do you see?

ELENA

Well. they're not----in this family.

RAY

Mamma, make her shut up, will you.

MRS. JARROTT

Elena!

(Enter MR and Mrs. Sturtevant and Marjorie, ushered in by James.

Sturtevant is an expansive, pompous, portly individual. He exudes affluence and importance. His wife also a large woman of the handsome, militant type. Marjorie is pretty and timid, very evidently under the thumb of her imposing parents.

Ray hurries to meet them eagerly). Mrs. Sturtevant advances upon Mrs. Jarrett, who has arisen)

RAY

Mother, may I present Mrs. Sturtevant --and Mr. Sturtevant.

(Mrs. Jarrett with a forced smile and Mrs. Sturtevant with cordiality for her, shake hands).

MRS. JArrott

How do you do, Mrs. Sturtevant-----Mr. Sturtevant.

MRS. STURTEVANT

I'm delighted to meet Ray's mother.

RAY

You've met Marjorie, mamma.

MRS JARROTT

Yes indeed-----come and sit beside me dear.

(Marjorie and Elena have had a moment's excited whispering to one side. Marjorie now comes shyly forward. Mrs. Jarrott puts her arm about her)

RAY

This is my sister---Elena.

MRS. STURTEVant
(Smile slightly congealing as she looks at Elena)

Ah yes, Elena. I'm very glad to meet you, my dear. I've heard so much about you.

ELENA
(Guiltily)

You can't believe everything you hear.

MRS STURTEVANT

Ray has often spoken about his little sister. He has tol told us many nice things about you.

ELENA
(Throwing grateful glance at brother)

Ray's pretty darned nice himself. If you ask me, Marjorie's a lucky girl.

(Mrs. Sturtevant coughs slightly. Ray is painfully embarassed. Mrs. Jarrott covers up the faux pas by drawing Marjorie down beside her on couch. Elena glances from one to the other).

ELENA

I would say the wrong thing.

(They are now all seated, except Sturtevant who stands at back of his wife's chair, looking about him. Mrs. Sturtevant sits stiffly in chair.

On couch Mrs. Jarrott, with Marjorie next to her. On the other side of Marjorie, Ray, head over heels in love with her).

(In the first gush of conversation, Elena manages to exit at left).

MRS STURTEVAnt

You have a very unusual place Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS. JArrott

Its the children's idea. They like ultra modern things.

(Sturtevant's exchange glances)

MRS. STURTEVANT

Personally, I would find this--futuristic you call it, don don't you?---I would find this futuristic furniture and decoration intriguing, but, shall I say, somewhat difficult to live with---is it not?

MRS JARROTT

One gets used to anything.

MRS. STURTEVAnt

Very true, my dear, though we have always lived in atmosphere of antique furniture. I do think, the antique savors of --er --shall we say--family--culture--breeding---.

(Ray is sitting on other side of Marjorie, and has managed to slip his hand over hers. He looks at her adoringly, and it is plain Marjorie is in love too.

MRS JARROTT

Oh yes, antique things are nice, but you know how young people are today.

MRS STURTEVAnt

And speaking of family, Mrs. Jarrott, are you from the Rochester Jarrott's. ✓

MRS JARROTT

No. We came from the west.

MRS STURTEVANT

Really! One would never guess that from your accent, would they my dear. (To husband)

STURTEVANT

Not at all. What part of the west are you from, Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT

(Slightly confused)

Oh --er--from Illinois.

STURTEVANT

Illinois---thats midwest. We have connections in Peoria. Perhaps you know the town, Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT

No. We left Illinois when I was a child.

STURTEVANT

Ah! I thought so. I knew you were educated in the east. Where?

MRS JArrott

Boston.

STURTEVANT

Indeed. Thats very interesting. You were ----

MRS JARROTT

My name was Mavor.

STURTEVANT

Splendid. I am very well acquainted with the Boston Mavor's. You are a relative of Dr. Mavor?

MRS JArrott

(More and more uneasy)

No, no, my father was --er --a railroad man.

MRS STURTEVAnt

That explains why you travel so much. Ray tells me he's been travelling nearly all of his young life.

MRS JARROTT

Yes, we're very fond of travelling .

MRS STURTEVANT

But Ray is tired of it, my dear---are'nt you my dear boy?

RAY

(Looking at Margery)

I'll say I am.

(Mrs. Sturtevant beams and sighs in sympathy. Mrs. Jarrott looks tired and somewhat apprehensive.

Off scene a peculiar whistle is heard--repeated three times. In the little pause that ensues, Elena is seen at back, slipping behind the stairs, getting her coat and hat from closet. Whistlimg repeated. Even devoted Ray hears it, and dropping Marjorie's hand he starts to get up)

MRS STURTEVANT

What a singular whistle---seems almost in the house does'nt it?

(Ray gets up with a word of excuse to Marjorie and moves swiftly toward where Elena is about to sneek out).

ELENA

(As her brother advances sternly upon her)

Darn! You would catch me.

(Drops coat and hat and comes forward with assumed casualness. Whistling again repeated. Elena winks at the frowning Ray)

STURTEVANTS

This city is overrun with gangsters and gunmen. I understand they all have theor own peculiar signals and whistles. It might be as well to notify the police department.

ELENA

(Giggling)

Then you'd be arresting one of your own men---Bunk works in your bank.

STURTEVANT

Bunk!

(Ray could murder his sister. He strides toward back)

RAY

I'll go bring him in. We won't stand for this. He cqn't come outside our house and make those crazy noises.

ELENA

He's just whistling. He wants me -----

(Ray exits)

MRS STURTEVAnt

What did you say the young man's name was?

ELENA

Bunk--we call him." Chester Whitehouse to other folks.

MRS STURTEVAnt

Chester Whitehouse---well, well.

(To Mrs. Jarrott)

Hixxpsspkx A good family--but--er--possibly Chester is a bit----

(She is about to say "wild" when at

back Ray enters, followed by BUNK, a cherubic looking young man.)

RAY
I think you know everyone here.

(Bunk bows around the circle. He feels awkward under the united stares. Behind Mrs. Sturtevant's back, Elena is winking at him and making signs, but stops short as she catches the eye of Mr. Sturtevant)

MRS JArrott
Won't you sit down Bu----

(She was about to say Bunk, but stops in time out of deference to the Sturtevants)

MRS STURTEVANT
How do you do Chester. How is your mother.

BUNK
Mother's all right.
(To Mrs. Jarrott)
I just dropped over to taken Elena for a spin around the lake.

RAY
Elena can't go out alone with you at night.

BUNK
No? Since when? She's been doing it for some time now.

(Ray glares at him)

Tell you what---what say you and Marjorie come along with us. Its a swell night, and I'm trying out the new Cord.

ELENA
Thats a swell idea. How about it Margery.

MArjorie
Oh mother, may I?

MRS STURTEVANT
Well--er---you're not accustomed to do things like that, but---I don't see any harm in it---what do you say, William.

STURTEVANT
Under the circumstances, its quite all right I suppose.

MRS STURTEVAnt
And so long as you 're not out too late.

(Marjorie pleased and excited jumps up. Ray too is delighted. The young people move off--)

MRS STURTEVAnt
What time will you be back?

ELENA
Let Marjorie spend the night with us, Mrs. Sturtevant.

MRS STURTEVANT
Marjorie has never spent the night away from her home.

ELENA
Well she's got to do it some day. Wait till she marries Ray----Oh by the way Bunk, Ray and Marjorie are engaged.

BUNK
No!

(Gives Ray a big handshake, and then with wide grin turns to Margery).

Do I kiss the bride yet?

RAY
Not on your life, you don't.

ELENA
How about it? Can Marjorie spend the night with us?

(Ray looks at his mother, waiting for Mr to second invitation).

MRS JARROTT
Do let her. It will be so nice having Marjery with us.

RAy
And she can go with me when I try out my new motorboat in the morning.

MRS STURTEVAnt
You don't mean--go <u>alone</u> with you Ray. Marjery is accustomed to being chaperoned.

ELENA
Chaperones belong among the antiques-----and

(Breaks off at look from Ray)

RAy
Won't you come with us Mrs. Sturtevant. We can have breakfast at the Club and then go out in the boat. You ought to see it---its almost a yacht.

MRS STURTEVANT
I'm sorry Ray, but I could'nt possibly go tomorrow morning? You know I'm President of the Wayward Girls Welfare League and-----

ELENA
But mamma can go with us--can't you, mamma. You'll--- ahem! ---chaperone Marjery, won't you?

(Mrs. Jarrott gives Elena reproving glance, and then replies sweetly)

MRS JARROTT
I'll be very glad to.

ELENA
Then thats settled and everybody's happy. Lets be on our way.

MRS STURTEVANT
Well Marjery, do you want to spend the night here?

MARJERY
I'm crazy to, mother.

MRS STURTEVAnt
Not crazy to, my dear. Thats not the proper word to use.

MARJERY
I'd like to very much, mother.

MRS Sturtevant
Well, I don't see any objection. What do you think William?

STURTEVANT
Quite all right.

MRS STURTEVANT
What about clothes dear. You can't go aboard a yacht in evening clothes.

ELENA
Don't worry. I've heaps of things, and we're about the same size, though Marjery has more curves than I.

(The young people exit. Sound of motors leaving &c.

(Mrs. Jarrott and the Sturtevants resume their seats. A slightly awkward silence ensues. Mrs. Jarrott is visibly nervous and dreading what she fears may be an inquisition).

MRS JARROTT
(Making conversation)
Marjery seems such a sweet girl.

MRS STURTEVAnt
In that I can fully agree with you. Our little Marjory is precious. Your son is acquiring a treasure.

(She wipes her eyes and sniffs)

STURTEVANT
There, there, my dwar. Don't forget that in Ray we will be getting a fine son.

(Mrs. Jarrott is looking before her in nervous suspense. Mr. Sturtevant looks at his wife, raises his eyebrows. She slightly nods. He draws his chair up nearer to the couch on which the two women are seated).

STURTEVAnt
Mrs. Jarrott, will you pardon me if I ask you a few questions.

MRS JArrott
What is it you want to know, Mr. Sturtevant?

STURTEVANT
Merely the things that any parents are entitled to know when their only child is about to marry a --er --- stranger.

MRS JARROTT
Yes---I suppose we are strangers in this town.

MRS STURTEVANT
That is no crime, my dear. We cannot all be born in Edmonton. Of course, the Sturtevants have been here for several generations. In fact our chief Boulevard is named for the Sturtevants.

MRS JArrott
Yes, yes---I've heard all about the Sturtevants. I -- I'm afraid I don't consider family so important as-- other things.

MRS JAURTEVANT
Why Mys. Jarrott, what could be more important than -- family.

MRS JARROTT
Lots of things---I --I ---could'nt name them all. Character--and --~~mmmmm~~ honesty and---Oh so many things.

STURTEVANT
Very fine, Mrs. Jarrott, and all more or less connected with family. Tradition--from generation to generation.

MRS JArrott
(Looking at him---at bay)
Well, just what is it you want to know about us.

STURTEVANT
(Clearing his throat)
I would have preferred to speak to Mr. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT
I'm sorry--he's away.

MRS STURTEVAnt
He's away quite a lot, is he not?

MRS JARROTT
Yes.

STURTEVAnt
He has business interests in New York?

MRS JArrott
I won't discuss his affairs. Will you please ask the questions you have come here to ask.

STURTEVAnt
What is Mr. Jarrott's business.

(Mrs. Jarrott catches her breath. She starts to answer and then stops She does not know what to say.)

I took the liberty of asking for his financial rating from Bradstreets and Dunn.

MRS JARROTT
Why---why---you had no right to do that!

No right? STURTEVANT
My dear lady, it was the perfectly natural and legitimate thing to do, under the circumstances.

MRS JARROTT
Yes---yes---I suppose so-----under

MRS JARROTT
Yes--yes---I suppose so--under the circumstances as you say. Well--then--you have his rating.

STURTEVANT
Unfortumately no. They could give me no rating of Mr. Jarrott, beyond his accounts here in Edmonton, which are purely nominal.

MRS JARROTT
(Agitated)
I won't have Mr. Jarrott's affairs pried into. If you're not satisfied-----

STURTEVAnt
You are unnecessarily excited. After all, put yourself in our place. Marjery is used to the best in everything. We are concerned in knowing that the man she marries will be able properly to provide for her.

MRS JARROTT
You need feel no concern as to that. Ray is provided for by a trust fund. He is rich in his own right.

(The Sturtevant's exchange glances. They are palpably relieved, and they realize they have gone too far in questioning Mrs. Jarrott, who is nearly on the verge of a collapse)

MRS STURTEVANT (Rising)
William, I'm afraid we've tired Mrs. Jarrott. In any event I feel sure, Mr. Jarrott is the one you should speak to. There is just one matrer I should like cleared up. Mrs. Jarrott, do let us know something about your family. You see, I myself am a Brookside--of the Clayton Brooksides, in fact. I'm past Regent of the local chapter of Colonial Dames and of the Daughters of the American Revolution and----

MRS JARROTT
You'll have to take Ray just as he is. What does it matter who his people are or where we came from. He will make Marjery a good husband---I am sure of that.

STURTEVAnt
For the present, at least, that is all we need to know. Come my dear it is getting quite late.

(Mes. Sturtevant glances at wrist watch and starts)

MRS STURTEVAnt
Why, its nearly ten and those children are'nt home yet. Perhaps we are rather oldfashioned, Mrs. Jarrott, but we have brought Margery up with great care.

MRS JARR

MRS. JARROTT
Marjory will be all right with us, I'm sure.

(She accompanies them to the hall. Off stage sound of parting greetings. A pause, and then Mrs. Jarrott comes slowly into the room. She stands a moment in a painful abstraction. Then she sits on couch, her fingers absently running through her hair, with a distracted motion. She speaks in a whisper, but clear enough for audience to get what she is saying:

What, in heavens name, am I going to do?

CURTAIN LOWERED OR STAGE DARKENED to denote brief passage of time.

(While curtain rising, or stage lighting up, we hear the sound of automobiles outside; the noise of the arrival of the young Jarrotts and a number of their friends. The front door banging; gay young voices in hall; laughter, and presently the music of radio, dancing &c. This is all off stage, toward the solarium).

(In living room, Mrs. Jarrott is smoothing her hair, powdering her face &c. to offset her recent emotion.

Enter ELENA and BUNK. Bunk is slightly tight)

ELENA
What! Still up mammma.

MRS JARROTT
I was waiting up for you.

ELENA
We're going to throw a party. Brought the gang along--picked them up en route. Listen to them--the bums!

MRS JARROTT
Well enjoy yourselves, dear.
(Her voice reflects her weariness)

Bunk moves to Elena.

BUNK
C'mon Elena, on with the dansh! Let joy be unrefined!

(Takes Elena by arm)

ELENA
No sir, I'm not going to dance with you. You're drunk!

BUNK
Drunk yourself. You drank more than I did.

MRS JARROTT
Children, don't talk like that. Elena, really, I think you should be in bed at this hour.

ELENA
In bed? Why the night is but a pup!
(Laughing she exits. Bunk starts to follow then turns back to Mrs. Jarrott, laughing)

BUNK
Mrs. Jarrott, what say <u>you</u> dance with me.

MRS JARROTT
No thank you. Not tonight.

BUNK
Let me press you---
(Takes her by arm)
You know you may be along in years but you got young looks.

And I bet you got young feelings too!

(As he speaks Ray enters. He half smiles half frowns, shaking his head like an older brother at Bunk)

RAY

Get along with you Bunk. I won't have you bothering my lovely mother.

(Bunk retires, slightly staggering toward exit)

(Alone with his mother Ray puts his arm about her and gives her a good kiss)

Just had to come in and give you a good night hug, mamma. You don't know how happy I am!

MRS JARROTT

I'm glad you're happy, darling.

(She looks up at him wistfully)

very

Ray, you take life seriously don't you?

RAY

You're dead right I do.

(Mrs. Jarrott sighs)

MRS JARROTT

Really you know, you are years older than I am.

(Kisses him gently)

RAY

Mamma, is'nt Marjory the most adorable girl you've ever seen.

MRS JArrott

She's very sweet dear.

RAY

And her people are all right too--once you get used to them. A bit stiff and all that--but----

(James, the butler, enters. During the foregoing and ensuing scene music and sound of laughter and dancing and chatter heard off stage).

MRS JArrott
What is it, James.

JAmes
Beg pardon, I thought I should tell you that theres a person outside the house----

MRS JARROTT
Well? What does he want?

JAMES
I don't know maam, but I don't like his actions. He's been snooping around the house--both back and front, and has been peeping in at the window. Seems to be watching the house.

(Mrs. Jarrott begins to realize in a blind sort of way something is impending)

RAY
Go on out and ask him what he wants. Tell him to come in.

JAmes
Yes, Mr. Ray.

(Mrs. Jarrott stands tensely her eyes flickering toward where James has gone)

RAY
You look tired, mamma. You'd better get to bed. Its been a strain on you.

MRS JARROTT
I'm all right Ray.

RAY
No you're not. Anyone can see you're not yourself. Off to bed for you. Want you to get your beauty sleep so you'll be nice and fresh to go aboard with Marjorie

and me in the morning. (Boyishly)
Say mamma, Margery thinks you're swell. She told me so. She said-----

(Enter James with a stockily built, clean shaven man of about 40)

RAY
Who is you want to see.

MAN
Mavor's the name---Miss Sylvia Mavor.

RAY
Who?

(Man puts on glasses and examines paper in his hand.)

MAN
Yes--thats the name ---Sylvia Mavor--alias Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JArrott
I'm Mrs. Jarrott, what do you want?

MAN
I've a paper here for you, madame.

(He extends paper. Ray starts to take it from him, but the man holds back)

Sorry sir, but I have to serve this personally on Miss Mavor or Mrs. Jarrott.

RAY
What do you mean--serve. What is that paper.

MAn
Its a subpoena, in the case of-----

(Mrs. Jarrott comes in between Ray and the man. Her voice is harsh)

MRS JARROTT
Ray, I'll attend to this matter. Leave us, please!

RAY
But whats it all about? Why should he serve you with a subpoena.

MRS JARROTT
Never mind why. Do what I say---leave us alone.

(Her voice has risen. Ray looks at her in astonishment, and then obeys his mother and exits.

Mrs. Jarrott turns swiftly to the man)

MRS JArrott
Now--tell me---what is it? ---what is that paper--

MAn
Its a subpoena. maam---

(Examining it)

In the case of Mrs. Edith Brundage versus Senator Kenneth Brundage, for Separate Maintenance with alimony.

(Again studying it through glasses)

You are named as co-respondent, maam, and this is a subpoena to enforce your presence at the trial.

(As he speaks, Mrs. Jarrott is almost about to faint. Her fear and terror are fought back, and she recovers herself finally)

MRS JArrott
Thats all right. Give me the paper.

(She looks at the man with wide tragic eyes)

Thats all---please go.

MAN

MAN

I'm sorry if I've distressed you maddam, but I was only doing my duty as a Process Server. I'm from the firm of Naylor, Naylor & Hutchinsons. Heres my card.

MRS JARROTT

Goodnight.

(Man stares at her, puts on his hat, nods briefly and exits)

(Mrs. Jarrott, slowly opens paper and starts to scan it. A half muffled cry escapes her, but she thrusts the paper behind her, as ELENA enters)

ELENA

Heh! Where's Ray? Ray!

(Ray comes on from side. He looks slightly troubled, and watches his mother anxiously)

You're a nice one to leave Margery so long.

RAY

Well, mamma---

MRS JARROTT

(With assumed brightness)

Go back to Margery Ray. I'm quite all right.

RAY

But what was that paper about?

MRS JARROTT

Just a business matter Ray. I am a little tired. I think I'll go to bed.

(Ray watches her as she moves unsteadily toward stairs. Up a few steps, she suddenly sways and falls.

Ray springs to her side, lifts her up. Elena

screamm, and several of their young friends rush on. Margery who has come with the others runs to Mrs. Jarrott and kneels beside her.

Mrs. Jarrott comes to quickly. Her hand is still tightly clutched about the subpoena. She tries to smile and to put back the loving hands)

MRS JArrott
Well how stupid of me. I tripped--on the stair.

ELENA
You passed out, mamma.

MRS JArrott
Oh no. Not as bad as that.
(She is speaking faintly, with an effort)
I don't want to spoil your party. Ray says I must get my beauty sleep for tomorrow.

MArgery
Oh but we won't go tomorrow if you are not well, Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JArrott.
But I feel fine---just sleepy.

(She starts to go up the stairs, Ray and Marjorie holding her by arm on eith side)

RAY
(Over shoulder)
Elena, clear everyone out. Margery and I will take care of mamma.

MRS JArrott (Protesting)
But I tell you I'm quite all right.

(They exit upstairs)

ELENA
(Flapping hands at crowd)
Kous mid dir, you bums! Out you all go---you too Bunk.

(She follows them out to hall. Ad lib sound of goodbyes &c. Starting motors)

ELENA's voice
(Off stage)

Nightie everybody----see you again soon.

(Elena comes back into room. She starts to move toward stairs. Front door bell heard. Elena stops. Moves as if to answer, but James is before her.

He comes back with a telegram on silver tray)

ELENA
I thought that was one of the gang coming back. What you got there, James.

JAmes
A telegram for Mrs. Jarrett, Miss Elena.

ELENA
I'll take it to her. She's not well.

JAmes
I'm sorry to hear that Miss Elena.

ELENA
Oh its nothing. At her age you have to expect anything you know.

(She takes telegram. James exits)

(Elena turns telegram over in hand. Ray enters from down the stairs)

ELENA
Theres a telegram for mamma. Do you think we ought to give it to her now.

RAY
Of course not. She's resting now, and Marjorie's with her.

What a wonderful girl she is, Elena. What a comfort she will prove to mamma.

ELENA
(Looking at telegram)
Gee! I don't like telegrams. You never know whats in them till you read them.

RAY
Dad wires mamma every day in the week.

ELENA
I know--just to say he loves her and all that; but just suppose a brick was to fall on his head or there was an earthquake or something like that, well then, someone else would have to wire and break the news.

RAy
Don't be silly. Elena, don't you think Margery's eyes are the loveliest-----

ELENA
You never can tell whats going to happen in this world. In the midst of life we are in death as OOMcIntyre says. and mamma should be spared any shock. I guess I ll open the telegram and read it---what do you say?

RAY (In clouds)

Suit yourself.

(Elena slips thumb under flap of envelope. Takes out telegram. Her brows pucker as she reads)

ELENA
Thats a funny telegram.

RAY
Whats it about?

ELENA
Its from dad. He says:
(Reading)
Don't let the children see the papers. Now I wonder what he means by that.

RAY
(Still in clouds)
Some legal papers probably. Mamma got one tonight.

ELENA

Yeah--but why does'nt he want us to see them.

RAY
I don't know why. Suppose because it does'nt concern us. Elena, have you noticed what a lovely smile Margery has.

ELENA
Gosh! You have got it bad, have'nt you?

RAy
Elena, we don't know what life is--till we ---love!

ELENA
Bologny! Come on--you better get some sleep.

RAY
I don't feel as if I could ever sleep again. I don't need to. I don't want to. My brain's just full of one thing--Margery--Margery!

(Elena pats her mouth in yawn, then slips hand through his arm, and they exit)

(Presently, James comes on and puts out the lights. The stage is in semi darkness.

Presently, Mrs. Jarrott comes softly down the stairs. We see her steal across the stage to telephone. She picks it up, dials.)

MRS JARROTT
(At phone)
Long Distance?

I want you to get me Senator Brundage---yes--Brundage.

Washington--D.C.

Curtain falls, as she waits at phone.

ACT II.

Scene I.

SCENE — Same as Act I.

About ten o'clock the following morning.

AT RISE — The telephone is ringing.

Enter James and goes to telephone.

JAMES
(At telephone)
Mrs. Jarrott's residence.

Mrs. Jarrott is not at home.

(While James is still at telephone, the front door bell rings. He hurries to answer it as soon as he is through at telephone.

While he is at the front door, the telephone rings again.

Enter NINETTE, a Maid, at left. Before Ninette can pick up phone, James is back, takes it from her and answers.

Mrs. Jarrott's residence.

No sir, Mrs. Jarrott is not at home.

(About to hang up)
I'm sorry sir, but I have already told you that Mrs. Jarrott is not at home.

I can't say, sir.
(Hangs up)

NINETTE
Mon dieu! Dat telephone she reeng all morning.

JAMES
(Sooly)
Are you through with your work in here, Minette.

MINETTE
Un moment.

(She dusts industriously for awhile, bent on lingering; then stops and looks excited as both telephone and front door bell ring simultaneously.)

De front door bell---he also ring all morning.

(Moves to answer phone)

JAMES
Never you mind, Minette. You attend to your duties. I'll attend to mine.

(Minette slightly shrugs, and moves reluctantly toward exit. James takes receiver off the hook, leaves it there and goes to answer the front door.

ENTER from head of stairs ELENA. She has apparently just gotten up and is still sleepy. She comes down patting her mouth as she yawns, and moving across the room. stretches herself on couch.)

(Minette is still lingering curiously).

ELENA
Say, wheres the morning paper, Minette.

MINETTE
I do not know, Miss Elena. Jaime--he take heem in theese morning.

(Off stage the sound of voices raised, and James very firm and polite tone stating)

JAmes
Mrs. Jarrett is not at homm.

(The emphatic closing of the front door follows, as though James had abruptly ended the conversation)

ELENA
(Stretching herself)
Get me the paper, theres a good egg, Winette.

WINETTE
I will try to find him, but I do not see the papaire theese morning.

(She exits at back, while James is coming in).

ELENA
Morning James.

JAMES
Good morning, Miss Elena.

(He is moving toward phone)

ELENA
They all beat me to it this morning.

JAMES
I believe you were asleep Miss, when they left.

ELENA
Well for crying out aloud, the could've wakened me.

(She stretches)

James
(At telephone)
Hello! Hello!

(He waits a moment, then hangs up. Evidently the party has left the line. James looks a bit uneasily at Elena, and then hurries once again to answer the front door bell, which is persistently ringing.

This time, apparently James is having some difficulty. Sound of dispute.

Elena puts her head over back of couch, and looks toward voices. She kneels up on couch to see better)

ELENA

WHo is it James?

(James is trying to hold back a young man, who seems to have successfully forced his way into the house. He enters alongside the protesting James, at back.
He is a good looking, not overly neat, but alert young fellow, and Elena regards him with girlish interest.
Before James can answer her query, the young man is in the room).

JAMES

You must leave this house, sir. You have your impudence forcihg your way in.

YOUNG MAn

Thats all right. I want to see Mrs. Jarrott---not you.

JAMES

I have already informed you that Mrs Jarrott is not at home.

ELENA

What does he want? Who is he?

YOUNG MAn

My name's Stewart---I'm from the United Press.

JAmes (Desperately)

Mrs. Jarrott is not in, sir.

ELENA

(Coquetishly)

But her daughter is. I betchu he wants an interview---now don't you.

STEWArt

You're a mind reader.

JAMES

Miss Elena, I feel quite sure your mother would not approve of your ------

ELENA

Be yourself James. Was I born yesterday? Exit please.

(James reluctantly moves to back, but does not entirely exit during scene, though he appears to be engaged in certain duties).

Sit down please.

(To Stewart)

I bet I know what you want to interview us about.

STEWArt

(Grinning)

Maybe you do.

ELENA

Its about my brother's engagement is'nt it?

STEWArt

(Surprised)

Oh, is your brother engaged.

ELENA

Yes, of course. Is'nt that what you've come to interview us about.

STEWART

Sure --that, and other things.

(He eqts a look about the room. Elena strikes an effective pose on couch. She smiles at the reporter)

ELENA

You have'nt asked me who my brother is marrying.

STEWArt

Well who is he marrying?

ELENA

Why Margery Sturtevant of course. Guess you know who the Sturtevant's are----first family in Edmonton!

STEWArt

WHAT! You mean your brother is engaged to the daughter of the President of the First National Bank of Edmonton.

ELENA

I'll say he is.

STEWArt

Tell me something else.

ELENA

(Archly)

About me? I expect I'll be bridesmaid.

STEWArt

Tell me about all of you. Whats your real name?

ELENA

Miss Jarrett of course---Elena Adelaide Jarrett.

(Reporter writes it down)

STEWArt

Where were you born?

ELENA

Me? I mean--I? I don't know.

STEWArt

Don't know where you were born?

ELENA

Well it was on a yacht---I know that.

STEWArt

Oh--so your father has a yacht, eh?

ELENA

A swell one. Its named--- after mamma---Sylvia. Say----

(She begins to look a bit troubled)

You're asking a lot of questions.

STEWART

Thats part of my job. Tell me some things about your father. Does he actually live here?

ELENA

Now where do you suppose he'd live if not in his own home?

(Telephone rings and James comes in and answers)

James
(At telephone)

Mrs. Jarrett's residence.

I'm sorry Madame, but Mrs. Jarrett has not yet returned.

I can't say, madame.

I', expecting them any moment madame.

ELENA

Who is it James.

JAMES
(At phone)

Mrs. Sturtevant, Miss.

ELENA

I'll speak to her.

(Runs over and seizes phone from James. The latter looks suspiciously at reporter and exits.
Stewart looks about him appraisingly. Then he concentrates upon what Elena is saying at phone).

ELENA
(At phone)

Hello, Mrs. Sturtevant, is that you? This is me---I mean I---Elena.

What was that you said?

What!

Say who do you think you're speaking to!

You know Marjorie was going with my mother and Ray.

Do as you please. Come over if you want to---but I tell you they're not home yet.

WHATS THAT YOU SAID? Why you old------

(Bangs up receiver. Stamps her foot. Almost ready to cry with rage)

Of all the doggone nerve. I never did like that woman. What do you suppose she said to me?

STEWART
(Eagerly)
What did she say.

ELENA
Why she said-----
(Pauses)
I forgot--you're a reporter, and if I tell you anything, you'll put it in the papers. No! I have nothing to say for publication.

STEWArt
Come on now, tell me--just what did Mrs. Sturtevant say.

ELENA
No ----I'm not talking for publication.

STEWArt
Well, tell me something about your father and mother and the rest of the tribe.

ELENA
Nothing to tell. We're just ordinary nice people.

STEWArt
Your mother was an actress before----

ELENA
Actress---Mamma! Don't be funny.

STEWArt
Many relatives?

ELAine
None that I know of---worse luck.

Stewart
Your mother's father was a railroad conductor, was'nt he?

ELENE
(Hurt)
Condnctor? He was a railroad man.
(Reporter suppresses smile, and Elaine is more uneasy)
Gee! I wish they'd get home. I don't like being interviewed Anyway I think you're too---too --kind of fresh.

STEWArt
I'm sorry. I did 'nt mean to be. I merely wanted to ask a few questions.

ELENE
O.K. Shoot then.

Stewart
Lived in Edmonton long?

ELENE
We never live anywhere long. Been here about six months now. Thats long for us.

STEWART
I see. Move from town to town, eh?

ELENE
We've lived lots of places.

STEWArt
New York-----Washington?

ELEN
We've been in New York all right. We had a scrumptious pent house on Park Ave. last time we were there.

STEWART
Go to school there.

ELENA

No. Ray and I used to have governesses and tutors when we were'nt at boarding school, but now Ray's just finished his sophomore year at Hamilton College---thats up New York State---and I'm going to Vassar, if I can get through matric. We're home now--thank goodness. Summer vacation.

STEWArt
(Craftily)

What do you mean by home.

ELENA

Whereveer mamma and daddy are.

STEWArt

But do they live together.

ELENA

What do you mean, do they live together.

STEWArt

But is'nt your father away most of the time.

ELENA

He's away lots. He has to be. His business keeps him away.

STEWArt

And what's his business?

ELENA

Why he---he's an --investor. He invests money. So that takes him to New York nd Chicago and other big cities--but he always rushes back. He can't stay away long from mamma.

STEWArt
(Quickly)

Why not?

ELENA

Because he's so crazy about her. You'd think they were newly weds. Daddy's as much in love with mamma as he was when they were married.

STEWArt
When they were --what?

ELENA
Married.

STEWArt
Oh--were they married?

ELENA
Why, all married people are married, silly.

STEWArt
Well--er---when were they married.

ELENA
How should I know. I was'nt alive then----Listen? That sounds like our car.

(Runs to window and looks out. Reporter right at her heels.

Off stage, sound of arrival, and presently, enter from back MRS JARROTT, MARGERY and RAY. They do not immediately see the reporter, who is standing somewhat to one side now. They are in yachting or sports clothes).

RAY
Say---whp are those people outside. A photographer snapped us as we came in. Has anything happened?

ELENA
Its on account of your engagement. Look, heres a reporter right in our house and he's been interviewing me.

(Mrs. Jarrott, her eyes wide and dark, stares fixedly at reporter. Ray looks at him suriously, Margery, shyly)

ELENA
He's here about your engagement-----

STEWART
Not about that but------

(Ray is about to speak to him, when Mrs. Jarrott runs in between him and reporter. She speaks in an anguished whisper)

MRS JARROTT

Ray---don't speak to him! Don't say a word!

(To reporter)

We've nothing to say---Not a word----not a word. Please go.

(As reporter does not move)

James! James!

(James enters)

Show this man out.

RAY

Why mamma, I don't mind speaking to him. Do we, Margery?

MARGERY

Whatever is the proper thing to do. Should'nt my mother give out the announcements first.

RAY

Thats right. I'm sorry Mr----

STEWART

Stewarts my name.

RAY

Stewart. We'll have something to say---later.

STEWART

I've a pretty good story now.

(Exits with James doggedly at his heels)

MRS JARROTT

(A prey to intense agitation. She tries to command herself but can scarcely speak)

Elena, what did you tell that man.

ELENA

Oh everything about us. He asked a million questions--- where we were born and when where you and daddy were married, and where we were brought up and what daddy's business was, and if he lived here with us----and---

MRS JArrott

Don't tell me any more.

ELENA

Should 'nt I have told him anything, mamma.

MRS JArrott

Its done now.

(She stands in a sort of dumb trance)

ELENA

Well, guess you better all get changed before lunch.

(Margery gives a troubled look at Mrs. Jarrott.

MARGERY

Are you quite all right, Mrs Jarrott?

MRS JARROTT
(Pulling herself together)

Oh yes, yes. Come--we'll change.

(Mrs. Jarrott and Margery exit upstairs)

(Ray sits on couch. He seems a bit moody and troubled about something. Lights cigarette and then squashes it out)

ELENA

Have a nice sail?

RAy

The sail was allright---but----

ELENA

But what?

RAY

Well, mamma does'nt seem quite herself. Acts abstracted or distracted---as if something was on her mind.

ELENA

Oh she misses daddy. He's been gone three weeks now, and do you know she can't even get him on Long distance any longer. I heard her tell James so.

RAY
(Thinking)

Say Elena, did we ever do or say anything tom offend the Munsons or the Cowards or the Moore's---or any of that crowd?

ELENA

Not that I know of . Why?

RAY

Well, they all acted kind of queer to us this morning--- looked at us queerly, and did'nt speak to us even--and well Mrs. Munson, when mamma came up to her, kind of turned her back right around of her.

ELENA

You're crazy with the heat. Why would anyone in the world cut mamma?

RAY

Well, I tell you they did---they all did in a way--especially the Munson woman.

ELENA

We should worry about her. She's just an old alley cat. I'd like to spit in her eye. What did mamma do?

Ray

What could she do? She --well, I thought she kind of dropped her head, and just moved on--without a word.

ELENA

That does'nt sound like mamma. Did Margery see?

RAY

Naturally.

ELENA

Did she say anything?

RAY

No, but she looked kind of surprised and --er--hurt. You know Margery's such a sensitive, wonderful-----

ELENA

Now don't start raving about Margery. I know all about her.

RAY

I'm just mad about Margery.

ELENA

I know you are, poor kid.

RAY

Why poor---?

ELENA

Well, I dunno. I'd hate to have to marry a family like that.

(Ray bridles and starts to say something when the telephone rings.)

You answer Ray. Its probably the Sturtevant dame, and by the way--I wish you just could have heard what she said to me this morning----

(Ray is on his way to phone)

Why, I never was so insulted in my life.

(Ray is now at phone, and Elena shrugs as she realizes he is'nt listening to her) Elena exits at R.

RAY
(At phone)

Hello!

Oh good morning Mrs. Sturtevant.

Why--we only just got back. We had a swell sail and----

I beg your pardon?------

Marjory's with my mother.

I beg your pardon?

Wh-why, Mrs. Sturtevant, I don't understand you.

(Mrs. Sturtevant has apparently hung up at the otherend. For a moment Ray stares at the phone, puzzled and troubled. Then very slowly he puts receiver on hook)

(Elena enters in an angry impetuous rush)

ELENA

Well of all the nerve of those maids. Mamma ought to fire both Delia and Minette. There they wereReading the newspaper, their two heads chucked together, and when I asked for it, what do you suppose they did.

RAy

I have'nt the slightest idea.

ELENA

Well those two servants tried to hide the paper under the table, and when I reached for it, they actually tried to take it from me. Just look at it. All torn and crumpled. Wait till I tell mamma on them.

(Notices Ray's abstraction)

What's the matter with you.

RAY

Nothing--nothing.

ELENA

There is too, You're acting funny.

RAY

Well I just don't quite understand something Mrs. Sturtevant said to me. She was downright rude---almost insulting. I

I don't know whats got into her.

ELENA

You should worry about that old hen. Forget it. I told yuu how rotten she talked to me this morning. I'd like to push her face in.

(Elena sits on couch, smoothes out paper, begins to look at first sheet. Ray, troubled, pays no attention to her).

Yum yum, here's another big society scandal. I adore divorces and scandals and murders. Listen to this:

(Holds out the paper and reads headlines)

'Wife of Senator Brundage suing for separate maintenance with million dollar alimony. Charges that her husband has lived with another woman for twenty three yrars, under an assumed name. Woman named as co-respondent. '
Um! Fancy living with a paramour --thats the word, is'nt it? for twenty three years. They must be awfully old now.

RAY

Can't you keep quiet a moment. A fellow can't even think when you're around.

ELENA

Look at his wife! Would'nt a face like that stop a clock?

(A pause, as Elena continues to scan paper. Suddenly she speaks)

Ray!

RAY

What is it now?

ELENA

Does'nt he look like daddy?

RAy

Who looks like dad? What are you talking about?

ELENA

ELENA
This Senator Brundage. His wife's suing him and-----

RAY
I'm not interested in filthy scandals of that sort.

ELENA
But take a look at his picture. Its uncanny. He's the living image of daddy.

RAY
Well go ahead and read your paper to yourself--but leave me alone.

ELENA
Don't be so darned cross. You know Ray, you have'nt any fun in you---you're just too darned serious.

RAY
All right, I'm serious. Thats the way I'm made. So leave me alone.

(Mrs. Jarrott and Margery are coming down the stairs.
Elena is now reading the story again.
We get the girl's gradual reaction.
Her eyes widen. Her lips part. She sits up with a muffled cry--starts to speak---)

ELENA
Ray, Ray---its all about us. Read it--read it---

(Mrs. Jarrott rushes in between them, seizing the paper)

MRS JARROTT
No, no! Don't read it--for God's sake--don't! Don't!

RAY
Whats it all about mamma. Whats the matter.

MRS JARROTT
Let me tell you myself--in my own way. I --I -----

(Enter James)

JAMES
Mrs. Sturtevant is here, Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT
(Terrified)
Show her into the drawing room----Not in here---not in here!

JAMES
Yes Mrs. Jarrott.

(As he turns to exit, Mrs. Sturtevant enters. She comes in with a militant tread, casts a withering look at the Jarrotts, and goes directly to her daughter)

MRS STURTEVAnt
Come Margery! We must get out of this house as quickly as possible.

RAY
(Advancing to Mrs. Sturtevant)
Mrs. Sturtevant!
(Mrs. Sturtevant puts up a large hand)

MRS STURTEVANT
I have nothing to say to you young man. You've imposed on us long enough.

MARGERY
Mother--mother--what are you saying?

RAY
What have I done?

MARGERY
Yes mother, what in the world is the matter?

MRS STURTEVAnt
My poor child---my poor little girl. It is plain you don't know yet the shameful truth about these people.

MARGERY
They're lovely people. I --I love them all.

(Turns to Mrs. Jarrott)

Mrs. Jarrott---
(Sobbing almost)
Whatever is the matter.

(Mrs. Sturtevant forcibly draws Margery away from Mrs. Jarrott, with almost a protective way--as if to save her from contact with something unclean)

Mother--I won't go with you, till you tell me.

MRS STURTEVAnt
I'll tell you when we get home. Don't ask any questions now. You'll know only too soon. Come, my darling.

MARGERY
No. no--I won't! You've no right to come here and talk like this to my friends. You owe Ray and Mrs. Jarrott and apology.

MRS STURTEVANT
That does'nt sound like you Margery. I will not have you influenced by these people. We've been dragged into enough scandal as it is. As for apologizing
(She snorts)
Its not the custom to apologize to people of their sort.

RAY
What do you mean by that odious remark.

MRS STURTEVANT
Young man, I am not obligated to explain my words to you. I don't doubt but what you have known from the first, and are a party to the entire fraud.

RAY
What do you mean? I've a right to know what you are insinuating.

MRS STURTEVAnt

MRS STURTEVANT

I don't need to insinuate. I need only speak the truth. Do you mean to tell me that you are not aware of the fact that that woman has been the mistress of Senator Brundage for twenty three years.

(Ray leaps toward her almost as if he would strike)

RAY

You lying old hag---you take back those words!

MArgery

Oh Mother, have you taken leave of your senses?

RAY

She's lying--lying, I say!

MRS STURTEVANT

(With cold cruelty)

If I am lying, then every newspaper in the country is lying too. Read for yourself. Come Margery!

(She takes Margery by the arm. Margery tries to break away. She is in tears. The distracted Ray can scarcely see her for the agony of his mind)

MARJERY

Ray----Oh Ray!

(She tries to go to him, but her mother relentlessly draws her along. They exit.

Ray stands like one who has received a sudden, galvanic shock.

Mrs. Jarrett sinks down dumbly on the couch.

Elena sobs spasmodically.

Ray gazes at his mother bewilderedly.

Then his glance rests upon the newspaper on the floor. Slowly May bends and picks it up. His hands are shaking as he straightens out the paper. He begins to read).

SLOW CURTAIN.

ACT II.

Scene II.

SCENE: Same as previous scene.
A few minutes later.

At RISE of curtain, we see Mrs. Jarrott, Ray and Elena on stage, in practically the same positions as the previous act; but there is a terrifying tenseness about them.

Mrs. Jarrott cannot take her eyes from Ray. Elena, shocked out of all her natural gaiety, hovers near her mother.

Ray has just finished reading the newspaper story. His head is bent. At first we can scarcely see his face. Then he lifts his head and we see the contorted agony of his boy's face. More than agony--he is convulsed by an overpowering avalanche of rage.

Suddenly he crashes his clinched fist of his right hand into the newspaper. His voice is harsh, wild.

RAY

Lies! Lies! A pack of vile lies!

(He swings around on his mother, his voice rising).

Someone's going to be killed for this! I'll kill him!

(He approaches nearer to his mother).

Why don't you say something? What are we to do about

this odious story.

(Mrs. Jarrott tries to speak, but the words she choke in her throat. She is mortally afraid of her own son. She looks up at him desperately, puts her hand to her throat, shakes her head dumbly.)

ELENA

Leave mama alone. You're too rough.

RAY

I don't mean to be rough. Mamma, look at me----

(She tries to look at him, and her head drops in dumb shame and agony)

Mamma, we've got to do something. Did you hear what that woman said. Did you? She said that every paper in the country was printing that infamous story about us. I tell you. we've got to do something. We can't sit here and bear it.

(Mrs. Jarrott is making a superhuman effort to gain command of herself).

MRS JARROTT

Ray--Ray----

(Ray sits down roughly by his mother. She intuitively shrinks fearfully from him)

RAY

I'll run this story down to its source, if I die for it. I'll sue every paper in the country if necessary.

MRS JARROTT

We can't---we can't---we can't---do that.

RAY

What do you mean we can't?

MRS JARROTT

We can't I tell you. We don't dare----

MRS JARROTT
No, no---I tell you we can't.

RAY
With that filthy libel spread abroad on the front pages of every newspaper in the country, you say we can't do anything about it. Why not?

MRS JARROTT
Because we don't dare. Because----its the TRUTH!

(Ray stares at her. He does not fully comprehend the significance of her words. His eyes seem to become enlarged and to pierce through her.

She is breathing sobbingly. She has gt got it out now, and is like one at bay.

Suddenly Ray's two hands reach out and seize her savagely by the shoulders. Holding her back from him, he attempts to read her face. Her eyes cannot meet his for their desperate shame. She sobs spasmodically, her head drooped)

RAY
Its a rotten joke---a rotten joke!

(He shakes her almost savagely)
Say it was a joke! Say it---say it---well---speak--- do you hear me! Say it was a joke, mamma---say it, for God's sake!

(He keeps on shaking her as he speaks. Elena forces her way in between them, and tries to protect her mother from her brother's maniacal fury).

ELENA
Leave mamma alone. Take your hands off her.

RAY
(To Elena)
You keep out of this.

ELENA

Np---Np! I won't! I'm as much concerned as you are, if its true.

RAY

Its not true. It can't be true.

((He sweeps Elena foreible aside)

Now mamma----don't be afraid of me. Don't shrink back like that. Why I would'nt hurt you. I--I ---love you. You're my mother. I-----

MRS JARROTT

(In broken whisper)

Oh my boy!

RAY

You see---all I want to do is to help you. You think I can allow a thing like this to pass? So---don't you see darling, we must'nt joke about it. Tell us everything.

ELENA

(Kneeling beside her)

Yes mamma, do please.

MRS JARROTT

Very well, I will.

RAY

Thats it--thats it. Who put you up to this thing--this senseless joke.

MRS JARROTT

Its no joke. Its the truth!

(For a moment there is a dead silence in the room. Elena and Ray continue to look at their mother dumbly. Mrs. Jarrott is dead calm now---frozen).

Its true!

RAY

(Hoarsely)

You mean to tell me you are not married to-----Dad?

MRS JARROTT
(In dead voice)
I mean to tell you just that. I was never married to your father.

RAY
Christ Almighty!

MRS JARROTT
Ray--Ray---try to understand-----

RAY
I understand that for twenty three years you have been living with a man you are not married to. Right?

MRS JARROTT
Yes--but---

RAY
Theres no but about it. Its just the filthy truth.

MRS JARROTT
Let me tell you all. I've wanted to for so long. I've carried this secret till it has crucified me. I could not bring myself to tell you! I did not have the courage.

RAY
You could not bring yourself to tell us the abominable truth--but you could go on living it.

MRS JARROTT
How can I make you understand. Look Ray dear--you see-- it started when I was just a young girl ---Elena's age---

RAY
That paper there says you were an actress --a chorus girl.

MRS JARROTT
Yes--I was on the stage--just starting--in the chorus. Tha Thats all true. My people were poor--my father a train conductor. We came from a small town---I ran away from home. I ---I ---

How can I go on when you look at me like that----when you hate me so.

ELENA

I don't hate you, mamma. I love you!

RAY

Don't interrupt Elena. Our mother is trying to tell us how she came to live for twenty three years with our father, without being married to him.

MRS JARROTT

You are making it very hard for me, Ray.

RAY

Did you think it would be soft going?

MRS JARROTT

No, but if only you could have understood, I would have told you long ago.

RAY

Tell us now then.

(He looks strangely at her, without really seeing her. Ray is in some almost tragic state of mind)

So--you ran away from home and went on the stage. So you were an actress.

MRS JARROTT

No---nothing much on the stage. Hundreds of ~~girls~~ deluded girls fancy they have talent, when all they have perhaps is--beauty. I had that--when I met your father.

((Ray leaps up, striking his fists togethr. He then sits again)

RAY

Well, go on, go on---what else is there more to tell. ~~Smith~~

MRS JARROTT

Oh my son!

RAY
(Violently)
Don't call me that!

MRS JARROTT
But you are my son---my own dear boy. Oh Ray dear, its not as bad as you think. Your father and I loved each other. Does'nt that offset what we did?

RAY
No---nothing offsets the crime you committed.

(Mrs. Jarrott presses her hands together in anguish)

MRS JARROTT
Love is not a crime! Think of us dear--two people, loving each other, facing the world, defying the conventions, acknowledging no law but the law of our hearts.

RAY
Facing the world! You mean sneeking around in the background of life, moving from place to place like fugitives from justice! Do you call that facing the world?

MRS JARROTT
I tell you we loved each other, and our love was sacred--it was beautiful.

RAY
Love! You can't cover an illicit thing with cheap sophistry.

MRS JARROTT
(Slightly rocking herself.)
We loved!

RAY
And what of us? Had we no rights, Elena and I? Why should we be branded with your criminal passion. What did we ever do to be denied the right to a decent name.

MRS JARROTT
We'll go away somewhere ---anywhere. People forget easily. This will all blow over.

RAY
We are front page copy. We are lepers --- publicity lepers.

MRS JARROTT
Darling, no one will blame you or Elena. This is the twentieth century. People are broadminded. Hundreds of men and women have done what your father and I did.

RAY
Thats good. Broadminded people will pass it over. You've had your fun---love you call it. Well I'll tell you something. When a man loves a woman he protects her! Do you think I could subject Marjorie --- Marjorie---

(A sob breaks from the tortured boy. He covers his face with his hands. Scrambles his hands through his hair, and then leaps up distractedly)

MRS JARROTT
Ray darling, your father would have married me, if it had been possible. I have been his real wife in everything but name.

RAY
Name---thats what we have'nt got---Elena and I. We have'nt even a name.

(Elena bursts out sobbing)

(Mrs. Jarrott looks from one to the other)

MRS JARROTT
Ray your father will be home tonight. Wait till he comes.

RAY
My father---Thats rich!

MRS JARROTT
You are beside yourself.

RAY
Did you think it was something we could laugh off.

MRS JARROTT RAY
You are making a common thing of something that to your father and I was rare and beautiful. Ours was a real love!

RAY
Ye-eh. I know how you of his type love. That paper there said he was a rich young sport when he met you.

MRS JARROTT
And look what he is today----what he says I made him. I was his inspiration--his incentive. He has said so many and many a time.

RAY
What he is today! Ha----ha----one could almost laugh if it were not so--so----tragic. What is he today? A United States Senator----representing honest people. I'll tell you what he really is----a whited sepulchre--a damned Jekyll and Hyde, living a double life----

(Elena crying loudly makes a motion toward him as his fury mounts.
At Elena's scream Wimette appears at back; then Delia enters, followed by James, who furiously drives the two maids out.

Mrs James comes back into the scene.

Before the terrific condemnation of her son, Mrs. Jarrott has cowered, as though he were striking her physical blows).

James moves to Ray. He has a letter on a tray.)

JAMES
A letter for you, Mr. Ray.

RAY
Don't bother me! Don't bother me!

(James puts the letter in his hand. He looks at May anxiously, and then at the sobbing Elena and her mother. Without a word, but showing by his action his sympathy, James exits)

(May, letter in hand, mechanically looks at it, and starts)

MAY

Its from Margery! That's Margery's writing.

(Tears letter open. Feels inside. There is no letter, but a paper wrapped about something. It is the engagement ring.

May stares at it, and then holds it up with thumb and forefinger, swinging the little ring, as if critically examining it. A wild smile wreathes across his features, contorting his face. Suddenly he flings the ring vicelently across the room).

Look what Margery sent me-----look---its the engagement ring I gave her. She sends it back-----do you blame her.

(His head jerks back, and May bursts into crazy hysterical sobbing laughter. Still laughing, swaying like a drunken man, May moves off and exits. His laughter heard off for awhile).

ELENA

Well if thats the sort of girl Margery Sturtevant is its a good riddance to bad rubbish.

(She says this hysterically, and then sobers somewhat, as she looks at her mother)

Mamma---dear mamma--you look all in. Better to lie down a little while. Come on---I'll go with you

MRS JARROTT

No---I must wait here. May may need me. Your father may come. Oh Elena, what are we going to do?

ELENA

Mamma, try to think of me as --as ---grown up. I'm not the silly girl I was. You lean on me---leave it to me. You go up and lie down and rest till daddy comes. I'll wait for him.

(She helps her mother to her feet. They move toward stairs.

(Off stage a bell heard, but neither Elena or her mother pay any heed to it. Mrs. Jarrott is almost feeble. She tries to smile faintly, but her anxiety and misery are all too evident)

MRS JARROTT

But Ray? You don't think he'll do something --hurt himself---Oh dear, I don't dare to think of what might happen. Ray is so different to most boys of his age.

ELENA

Ray's a nut--and--and---he's in love.

(They exit upstairs)

(A pause, and then James seen a moment at door. Stands aside to admit Bunk Whitehouse).

(Elena coming back down the stairs. She does not see Bunk immediately. He stands back, very sober, watching Elena, as she sits on couch and buries her head in pillows. Little sobbing gasps come from her.

James exits.

Bunk comes around the couch. Stands a moment looking down at sobbing girl. Then very gently he puts his hand on her shoulder. Kneels down beside her. Elena starts up. She is almost in Bunk's arms. Bunk tries to smile)

BUNK

'Lo big girl!

ELENA

'Lo, Big Boy!

(Bunk takes out large handkerchief and wipes her tears away)

BUNK

There -now. Thats better. Stop bawling. Look cheerful, I'm taking your picture.

(Makes camera of his hands. Elena tries to smile, but it is a woful smile)

ELENA

What you doin' here, Bunk?

BUNK

Just dropped in on very particular business, if you must know.

ELENA

What business? Oh Bunk, we're in most awful trouble here.

BUNK

We all have troubles. You have'nt a corner on it. Look at me. Just been kicked out of house and home.

ELENA

What?

BUNK

Kicked out I said, after the darndest row.

ELENA

What did you row about?

BUNK

You.

ELENA

Me?

BUNK
Ye-eh--you. I told them I had an announcement to make. My impending engagement to you.

ELENA
Why Bunk, b-but we're not engaged.

BUNK
We will be if you say so--will you.

ELENA
I don't know. I ---you see ---we're not what you thought we were. Ray says we have'nt even a name.

BUNK
Thats all right with me. I got a pretty good one to give you.

ELENA
And he said-----of shh! Listen------

BUNK
Look me in the eye Elena. Do you or don't you love me?

ELENA
Don't you hear---Ray. He's talking to himself out there---Oh Bunk, poor Ray's just gone off his head.

BUNK
You have'nt answered me. Say yes or no.

ELENA
Yes or no.

BUNK
Then its all settled. We'll get married soon as possible. Now something else. I've been kicked out of my job too.

ELENA
Oh Bunk, I'm so sorry.

BUNK
Nothing to be sorry about. I got a better job than sitting on a stool in a bank. I landed me a taxi cab.

(Turns back coat and shows badge)

ELENA
Why Bunk, what will your family say?

(Bunk starts to laugh. Elena also starts to laugh, but stops midway).

Oh Bunk, we should'nt be laughing at this time. We should'nt be talking about marriage and things like that. Mamma will need me and-----

(She clutches his arm. Ray has suddenly come into the room. He appears to be utterly oblivious of their presence. His hair is rumpled up. He is in a distraught condition. He moves to center of room, muttering incoherently)

(Bunk's round face has become very serious. He goes to Ray, hand held out. Ray seems not aware of him)

BUNK
Hello, old man. How's tricks?

(Ray does not answer. Mechanically he tries to shake Bunk's grip from his arm)

Look here, fellow, if there's anything I can do--- you just ask me--will you. I'm going to be one of the family anyway.

(Ray looks at him queerly, as if not quite taking in his words. Then he kind of shakes his head.

Elena gently puts her hand through

Bunk's arm.)

ELENA

Come Bunk, you must go.

(They go slowly from room, looking back at Ray, till they exit)

(Ray is making long frantic strides across th the room, occasionally driving the fist of hi his right hand into the palm of his left.

He is muttering something under his breath as the CURTAIN falls).

CURTAIN

ACT III.

Scene 1.

SCENE: Same as in previous acts.

It is about six o'clock in the evening of the same day.

The room is slightly in shadow.

On stage, at rise, RAY JARROTT.

Almost the entire action of this scene is concentrated on the frantic pacing and repacing of the floor by the distraught Ray.

No word whatever is spoken.

No other character appears.

Nothing but the boy, gone plumb out of his head, and pacing and repacing the floor.

Once he sits down on couch, and holds his head in hands.

Almost immediately he is up again, repacing.

His hands are clinched, his face a poignant tortured mask.

Sometimes he flaps his hands. Again he runs them through his hair.

Thus pacing and repacing, up and down the stage, till presently, very slowly, the CURTAIN LOWERED, and remains a minute to mark a short passage of time, when it rises on the second scene.

ACT III.

Scene 11.

SCENE: Same as previous scene.

About an hour or so later.

The stage in semi darkness.

At opening: Ray is revealed still frantically pacing.

Enter James at left back. He pauses a moment to look with concern at Ray, who pays no attention to him, though James coughs, and waits for him to speak.

James moves across room and lights the floor lamps. Also straightens the room a bit.

He makes some noise purposely while doing this. Rustles the paper which he picks up and folds.

The noise and rustling of paper makes no effect on ~~James~~ Ray, who seems oblivious to his presence.

James pulls down the shades on windows at right, and draws the heavy curtains over French windows and doors at back.

JAMES

Is there anything more I can do for you, Mr. Ray.

(Ray makes no reply. James looks at him and then shakes his head.

He exits as Mrs. Jarrott and Elena come down the stairs. All the way down they are looking at Ray, still pacing.

When they reach the bottom, Mrs. Jarrott stands back a moment, while Elena runs to her brother).

ELENA

Ray----

(Without answering, Ray pushes her almost roughly to one side, and continues his pacing. Elena follows him. She is frightened and on the verge of tears)

Ray--I've got something to tell you. Its a big secret and-----

(Ray pays no heed to her)

(James enters)

JAMES

Dinner is served, Mrs. Jarrott.

ELENA

Ray
Yer its dinner time. Come on, old bean.
(He pays no heed to her)
Ray, we've got to eat, anyway.
(Her voice shaking)
Aw, come on, Ray-- be a sport. Snap out of it.

(She takes him by arm and tries to lead him. He moves automatically with her, but sees his mother, watching him with the most poignant expression. Ray stops abruptly. He glares at his mother, as if she were his mortal enemy. and she quails and trembles under his look.

Ray pulls his arm free of Elena's grasp. He goes to window at right, puts up the shade, and stares out blindly)

JAMES

Pardon me, Mr. Ray, but it would be better to keep away from the window.

(Ray stares at him uncomprehendingly)

Theres a lot of reporters and photographers and others out there.

RAY

Reporters! What are they here for?

(James does not immediately answers, and a hoarse laugh comes from Ray).

I'll tell you why they're here. They want to see us ----

(Points to his mother)

Her--Exhibit A---Elena--Exhibit B---Me--Exhibit C---and he, God damn his soul to hell!

(His words and actions are those ofmone whose mind has become unhinged)

(Mrs. Jarrott goes to him, her arms held out imploringly)

MRS JARROTT

Oh Ray--Ray---don't talk like that.

(She puts up her hands, almost as if shielding herself from a blow, as with a rush Ray comes up before her).

RAY

Well---what are we then? Are'nt we all exhibits. They'll have us all in court, won't they, and the lawyers and the jury and everyone else in the accursed place, will be pointing us out as --exhibits!

MRS JARROTT

Oh Ray, for pity's sake--for the love of God, don't speak--don't look at me like that!

RAY

How do you want me to speak? How do you want me to look? Do you expect me to be leaping with joy because my father and mother are'nt married-----

JAMES
(Interposing)
Pardon me, Mr. James, but won't you have your dinner.
Jarrett
(Ray prods him with elbow)

RAY
Get out of my way. Can't you see I'm busy. I've got to show my mother something. Its this--this--- do you see----

(He shows his mother the crumpled envelope in which Margery's ring had come).

Its from Margery--the girl I was going to marry. Was going to, you understand! She sent me back my ring. She could'nt marry a man who had no name even--- so she sent me back my ring.

(Incoherently)
Thats what the girl I love did---sent me back my ring -----

ELENA
That just shows the kind of girl she is. Oh Ray, come along, forget it-- Please, please, come along with me. A cup of tea won't hurt you, even if you don't feel like dinner. Come on, Ray!

(She cannot be shaken off. Ray glares down absently at her. She draws him along and they exit.

Mrs. Jarrett and James alone on stage)

James
Is there anything I can do to help Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT
No--thank you James---no one can help uus now.

JAMES
We have dinner ready for you Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT
No---I could'nt eat. Not now.

JAMES

If you'll pardon my saying so, a little dinner will give you strength.

MRS JARROTT

Yes--I suppose so. ✓

JAMES

I feel sure things will clear up as soon as your husband returns.

MRS JARROTT

My husband!
Thank you James! Nice of you to call him that.

JAMES

(Very respectfully)
Yes Mrs. Jarrott!

MRS JARROTT

(Desperately)
Oh, if he would only come. If he'd only send me word! I can't even get him on the telephone. The suspense is killing me.

JAMES

Did he not wire you last night?

MRS JARROTT

Yes, yes--he did'nt want the children to see the newspapers. But it was too late. Besides sooner or later they were bound to find out.

JAMES

You will have dinner then, Mrs. Jarrott.

MRS JARROTT

(Sighing wearily)
I may as well. Shuuu
(She moves toward exit, and then pauses and looks sadly at James)
You are a great help and comfort to us, James.

(Exits)

(James alone on stage. He stands thoughtfully a moment, his brows drawn. Autmatically straightens things up.
He goes to window, and without raising shades, he looks through the side. He straightens up alertly.

There is sound of someone at door off stage. If possible the effect of a latchkey, and door opened.

James hurries off back, toward door.

Off stage, a murmur of voices--men's, and then a voice heard clearly:

VOICE
I have nothing to say. Nothing!

(Sound of front door closing.)

(Enter from back, SENATOR KENNETH BRUNDAGE, followed by James).

(Brundage is a splendid looking man of about fifty--the well groomed, alert, man of the world type, yet with something savoring of the idealist and dreamer about him.

James holds his grips.

Brundage comes in swiftly.)

BRUNDAGE
Where is Mrs. Jarrott.

JAMES
She is at dinner,sir.

(Brundage looks about him.)

BRUNDAGE
Let no one in---no one, you understand.

JAMES
Yes sir. I'm attending to the doors myself.

(Telephone rings)

BRUNDAGE
Don't answer that telephone. Take it off the hook. Leave it off.

JAMES
Yes sir.

(James goes to telephone. He takes the receiver off the hook. Returns to Brundage, who is looking about him, till finally his glance falls on the newspaper, which James had folded and laid on table)

BRUNDAGE
How long have those reporters been out there?

JAMES
Most all of the day, sir, and there seems more of them every time I look. Some of them are photographers -----

BRUNDAGE.
Yes---they snapped me as I came in. I had hoped to beat the reporters--and came by private plane.

(His brows knot. It is plain he is troubled and annoyed)

Have my family been annoyed?

~~BRUNDAGE~~ JAMES
I'm afraid so, sir.

BRUNDAGE
Let Mrs. Jarrott know I am here----but I must see her alone.

JAMES
Yes sir I'm sure she'll be greatly relieved. She has been under a strain.

(James is about to exit when Brundage calls him back)

BRUNDAGE

One minute James.

JAMES

Yes sir.

BRUNDAge

We are going on a journey. We leave some time this evening. If possible, we must get away without being seen by---those men out there.

JAMES

I suggest, sir, that we wait till, say, toward morning.

BRUNDAGE

Yes--we had better do that. Have MacLean get the cars all ready, and tell him to keep his mouth shut.

JAMES

Yes sir. I'll slip over to the garage and give him your orders. Anything else, sir.

BRUNDAGE

You will go with us?

JAMES

(With devotion)

Yes sir---anywhere you go sir.

BRUNDAGE

Thats fine of you James. Now let Mrs. Jarrott know I am here.

(James exits.

(Brundage, a man of strong personality but with a fount of tenderness stands for a moment in thought. Then his glance goes back to the newspaper. He picks it up---unfolds it, and reads.

(Enter Mrs. Jarrott. For a moment, she stands, looking at Brundage, who is reading the paper. Then she utters a little muffled cry. He looks up, drops the paper, and they hurry to meet each other. The next moment they are clasped in each others arms.

They stand, closely embraced, murmuring endearing terms to each other.)

BRUNDAGE

My darling brave girl!

MRS JARROTT

Oh I'm not brave--I'm not brave. Kenneth---I'm afraid---I'm in terror---you don't know---you don't know.

(She puts her face against his breast and dry gasping sobs come from her)

(Still holding her in his arms, they move to couch and sit.

Brundage, one arm about her, lifts her face, with his other hand, and examines her gravely. Then he tenderly kisses her.

Mrs. Jarrott breaks from the embrace, holds him back with her two hands on his shoulders).

MRS JARROTT

Oh why did'nt you come sooner! You don't know what we've been through.

BRUNDAge

It was impossible for me to get away. My every move was watched.

MRS JARROTT

But why did'nt you telephone? Send me word of some sort.

BRUNDAGE
Our wires were tapped

MRS JARROTT
What does it all mean? Why at this late day are they-----

BRUNDAGE
Its a political frame-up. I'll explain later. My one concern now is to take care of you and our children.

(At back right Ray is seen. He stands stock still, watching his parents. They do not see him, as he stands by the alcove where the telephone is)

MRS JArrott
Oh what are we to do? In heavens name what are we to do?

BRUNDAGE
You are not to worry. I'll do the worrying for both of us.

(He starts to take her in his arms again, but she holds him back. She is in a fevered state, distracted and tormented).

MRS JARROTT
The children----what are we to do about the children?

BRUNDAGE
They know?

MRS JARROTT
Yes--it could'nt be kept from them.

BRUNDAGE
I was afraid of that--when I saw the paper there. Then they know.

MRS JARROTT
Everything.

BHUNDAge
How are they taking it?

MRS JARROTT
Oh Dreadfully. Elena does'nt quite comprehernd, but Ray---

BHUNDAGE
Ray---I can imagine how he would feel about it.

MRS JARROTT
He is nearly out of his mind. You never would believe the things he has said--the way he is acting. He is like a young Hamlet. He thinks--he thinks --his mother something--unclean.
(Sobs)

BHUNDAGE
Don't cry, my dearest . Everything is bound to come out right.

MRS JARROTT
But what are we to do about our boy?

BHUNDAGE
He's young. He'll get over it.

MRS JARROTT
No--no--he'll never get over it. Oh Kenneth, he'd just got engaged to a lovely girl.

BRUNDAGE
Engaged? Why thats ridiculous. Ray's only a boy---scarcely twenty one.

MRS JARROTT
I know, but Ray's old for his age, and they were so much in love. Her parents came to see us last night. Straitlaced, conventional people. The Sturtevants, you know them?

BRUNDAGE
If you mean the bank man here, yes, I've met him--pompous provincial type.